

Intrapartum Care – Study Notes

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I. Definition

Intrapartum care refers to the care provided to a woman and her newborn during labor and delivery, beginning from the onset of true labor until the delivery of the placenta and immediate postpartum period. It focuses on ensuring the safety and well-being of both mother and baby during childbirth.

II. Objectives of Intrapartum Care

1. Ensure a safe and normal delivery.
2. Provide physical, emotional, and psychological support.
3. Prevent, detect, and manage complications.
4. Promote early mother-infant bonding and breastfeeding.
5. Maintain aseptic technique to prevent infection.

III. Stages of Labor and Corresponding Care

1. First Stage – Cervical Dilatation

Monitor vital signs, uterine contractions, and fetal heart rate. Encourage comfort measures, hydration, and emotional support.

2. Second Stage – Expulsion of the Fetus

Encourage effective pushing, monitor FHR every 5 minutes, prepare sterile delivery set, and ensure safe delivery of the baby.

3. Third Stage – Delivery of the Placenta

Administer uterotonic (e.g., oxytocin 10 IU IM), perform controlled cord traction, and inspect placenta for completeness.

4. Fourth Stage – Immediate Recovery

Monitor vital signs, uterine tone, lochia, and perineal area. Promote skin-to-skin contact and breastfeeding.

IV. Key Principles

- Respectful maternity care.
- Continuous labor support.
- Evidence-based interventions.
- Infection prevention.
- Timely recognition of complications.

V. Common Complications

Prolonged labor, fetal distress, preeclampsia/eclampsia, postpartum hemorrhage, retained placenta, and perineal lacerations.

VI. Documentation

Record maternal vital signs, fetal heart rate, cervical progress, delivery details, medications, and newborn condition.

VII. Summary

Intrapartum care requires clinical skills, compassion, and vigilance. Effective monitoring, timely intervention, and supportive communication ensure positive birth outcomes for both mother and child.